enigmatic, but Dennis Sciama in Cambridge urged his students to journey down to London and hear it. As George Ellis, one of the students, recalls, "It was a very, very interesting lecture. Israel proved a theorem that came totally out of the blue; it was totally unexpected; nothing remotely like it had ever been done before." When Israel brought his lecture to a close, Charles Misner (a former student of Wheeler's) rose to his feet and offered a speculation: What happens if the imploding star spins and has electric charge? Might there again be just two possibilities: no hole at all, or a hole with a unique form, determined entirely by the imploding star's mass, spin, and charge? The answer would ultimately turn out to be yes, but not until after Zel'dovich's intuitive insight had been tested.

Zel'dovich, Doroshkevich, and Novikov, you will recall, had studied not highly deformed stars, but rather nearly spherical stars, with small mountains. Their analysis and Zel'dovich's claims triggered a plethora of questions:

If an imploding star has a tiny mountain on its surface, what is the implosion's outcome? Does the mountain produce enormous spacetime curvature, as the star nears its critical circumference (the outcome rejected by Zel'dovich's intuition)? Or does the mountain's influence disappear, leaving behind a perfectly spherical black hole (the outcome Zel'dovich favored)? And if a perfectly spherical hole is formed, how does the hole manage to rid itself of the mountain's gravitational influence? *What makes the hole become spherical?*

As one of Wheeler's students, I pondered these questions. However, I pondered them not as a challenge for myself, but rather as a challenge for my own students. It was now 1968; I had completed my Ph.D. at Princeton and had returned to my alma mater, Caltech, first as a postdoc and now as a professor; and I was beginning to build around myself an entourage of students similar to Wheeler's at Princeton.

Richard Price, a rough-bearded, two-hundred-pound, physically powerful young man from Brooklyn with a black belt in karate, had already worked with me on several small research projects, including one using the kind of mathematical methods needed to answer these questions: perturbations methods. He was now mature enough to tackle a more challenging project. The test of Zel'dovich's intuition looked ideal, but for one thing. It was a hot topic; others elsewhere were struggling with it; the